▼ GLASSHOUSE



WAXING SARCASTIC

Since former vice-president Jagdeep Dhankhar has resurfaced, senior BJP leaders have been calling journalists, trying to decipher his cryptic statements: "I wasn't ill, I was just prioritising my health..."; "I am really scared of bearded men these days...." Each aphorism sends the party's spin machine into overdrive. Insiders now concede that his exit in July last year was more acrimonious than that of the late former J&K governor Satya Pal Malik or ex-Union minister R.K. Singh, both of whom later became critics of the Modi regime. What has particularly unnerved the BJP brass is Dhankhar's demeanour during his recent public appearances, every statement delivered with philosophical barbs and knowing smiles. In Lutyens' Delhi, ambiguity often cuts deeper than accusation.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ THE SAMOSA PROJECTILE

FOOD FOR THOUGHT



No one understands the optics of a well-timed pit stop than former Uttar Pradesh chief minister **Akhilesh Yadav**. In Kanpur for a wedding, the Samajwadi Party chief stopped at the popular Munna Samosa shop, keeping an old promise and sharing a plate with his daughter and party colleagues. Within minutes, the crowd surged; shopkeepers reported selling over 1,000 samosas in 10 minutes. But never one to miss an opportunity, Akhilesh turned even the humble *chai ki dukan* into a ground for political theatre. "If we can't find politics in a samosa, what's the point?" he quipped, before taking a jab at CM Yogi Adityanath: "*Ek kachori, ek samosa...Dhongiji pe nahin bharosa* (One kachori, one samosa...but never trust a fraud)." In UP, you don't need rallies for campaign slogans to take flight. Sometimes, all it takes is a crowded snack shop for them to go viral.